all. The IPL is ultra-competitive; players put their pride and status on the line in the IPL, and of course there is a lot of money involved too. Yet the IPL allows you to become friends with players with whom you wouldn't normally spend time. Fidel Edwards, for example, is a really funny oke, and I've enjoyed getting to know Dwayne Bravo a little better too.

These players, though, have been on the periphery of my cricketing career. I would rather tell you more about the guys who featured significantly in my career. These are the players (and coaches) who, through their actions, whether negative or positive, have made an impression on me. And I thought I'd also give you a list of my favourite cricketers of all time …

Let's start with the good guys.

Vincent Barnes

Vinnie's been my best friend and mate for the past 20 years. Our friendship began when I first started playing for Western Province – he was one of my first roommates. Vinnie is 14 years older than me and was, at the time, nearing the end of his playing days. He would go on to become the Proteas bowling coach, which means that he has probably seen more of me than my family has.

Many a time Vinnie and I have shared a pot of tea together and discussed the intricacies and vagaries of the life we lead. It is something of a ritual – whenever he wants to chat, he'll always say, 'I think it's time for a pot of tea,' and we'll spend hours talking about life in general.

Whenever I've needed any kind of advice, I have turned to Vinnie. And whenever I've needed to open up and speak from my heart, Vinnie's been there for me. He's a really good listener and understands me completely. And he knows how to handle me. Sometimes he'll tell me what I want to hear, but at other times, he'll be completely blunt and say exactly how he feels.

Vinnie and I hardly ever talk about cricket, but he has always urged me to be more outspoken within the Proteas set-up. He feels I don't share enough of my thoughts or give enough input at team meetings and practices. Vinnie reckons if I were more vocal and shared my experience with the younger guys, it would be good for the team. I keep saying that if the team were more together, I would talk a lot more.